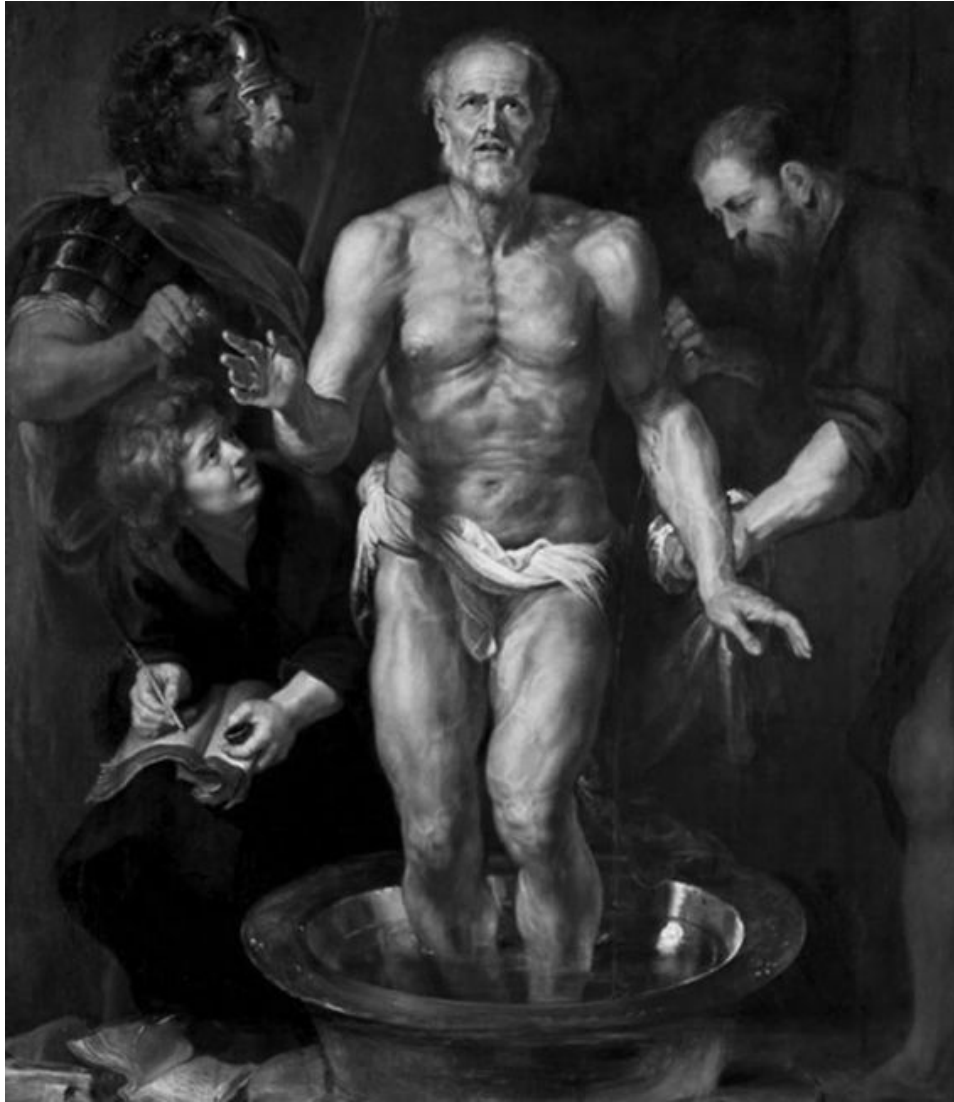


Stoics: philosophy of the Roman Empire



Ordered to commit suicide by the Emperor Nero in 65 CE, the stoic philosopher Seneca met his end with typical sobriety.

The last school of philosophy to emerge in ancient Greece, stoicism, evolved from the notion of virtue residing in simplicity and human nature proposed by the cynics. Zeno of Citium (not to be confused with Zeno of Elea, see [Zeno's paradoxes](#)), founder of the stoic school, taught that nature is the only reality, and that we are a part of it. Using our capacity for reason, we must learn to accept things we have no control over and also to control

our destructive emotions. Virtue alone is sufficient to ensure the happiness of a 'good life', and anybody who has knowledge of virtue and leads a virtuous life will not be affected by any misfortunes that befall him. The development of stoic philosophy coincided with the decline of Greek political and cultural influence and the rise of Roman power. The Romans, not previously known for their enthusiasm for philosophy, found stoicism fitted comfortably with their own culture of ethics, and it became the prevailing philosophy of the Roman Empire, adopted by thinkers including Seneca, Epictetus and Marcus Aurelius.